

Advanced Level

MARCEL'S BLUEGRASS COALITION BREAKS



TRANSCRIBED BY
Marcel Ardans

Lwm.102

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Produced for all the nerds out there that ask for tabs of my breaks,
it is always a humbling experience to put your own playing to paper.

Performed and transcribed by Marcel Ardans.

AUTHOR’S NOTE

The Bluegrass Coalition is a project that was started at the encouragement of our online community, more specifically an active group of players who socialize on my Discord server. Since fans and students span the globe, there was always a desire to bring more collaboration to the scene. Some folks don’t live in local communities with bluegrass jams, or some folks wanted to interact with their online friends they’d met. We found that planning a seasonal virtual jam was an awesome way to bring this idea to life.

Now, four times a year the self-titled Bluegrass Coalition “band” decides on a fiddle tune via Discord, picks a BPM and anyone is welcome to submit a performance for the YouTube video. Not everyone can make it into every single video, but that makes this project particularly fun. Each person has to practice, put their best foot forward and hope to make the cut.

This book contains all the tabbed breaks that I performed for the Bluegrass Coalition videos. Personally, I’ve only participated in four of the six performances, so at the time of publishing this book you’ll notice there are only four breaks. I have every intention of keeping this book up to date and adding more tabs as they are available.

In these breaks I always attempted to create a ‘meta-challenge’ for myself. This sometimes involves performance techniques like double stops, drones, crosspicking, or floating. Other times I’ve tried to quote some of my favorite musicians like Tony Rice, Roy Curry, Trey Hensley, Bryan Sutton and even a film composer in the case of Blackberry Blossom. Sometimes these challenges got the better of me (I admit the alternate tuning arrangement of Cherokee Shuffle that slowly increased 30 BPMs probably didn’t need those floating passages). Still, I hope these transcriptions help illuminate some of my personal methodology to anyone interested.

At the bottom of each tab I’ve included a brief explanation of my thought process of creating these breaks. But as a general rule I start by playing the melody of the tune over the chord changes (likely, provided by Strum Machine) slightly under tempo, then I’ll begin improvising passages. This is all exploratory, as I find things I like I add them to a mental roadmap. If I’m feeling particularly studious I might write some of the roadmap down. For example, the first line of Salt Creek I might have scribbled, “Double stops and box two pentatonic.” When this loose roadmap is completed I increase the tempo and hit record for the first time. I don’t want to plan every maneuver because in my experience that kills the spirit of improvisation. Instead I know what tools I’ll be using and where, I just need to get from place to place and execute on the plan. Generally I get a good take within the first ten attempts. I used a similar thought process in my personal albums, though admittedly some of those have been more composed.

I hope you enjoy this small look into my mind and find something useful in these transcriptions.

Marcel Ardans

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BILL CHEATHAM

AS PERFORMED BY MARCEL ARDANS

TABBED BY MARCEL ARDANS

Standard tuning

A PART

Capo. fret 2

B PART

The break starts with the melody followed by a variation on what my viewers call “The Marcel Lick”. This lick would normally finish with a G string escape note but instead ends with the G a sixth above at the start of the second line. Next, a stuttering interpretation of “That One Tony Rice Lick”. This lick also normally ends with a G string escape note but instead I descend the neck linearly.

Line three is all about double stops, Bryan Sutton creates similar passages and this is my attempt at that sound. This A part ends with a classic “hot lick” but instead of first position, I’m in the middle of the fretboard. The B part begins with a Roy Curry quote that concludes with a sixth interval. Continuing the interval play, the second line of the B part ascends in thirds through the chord changes, sliding into the 3rd of the current chord and followed by the 5th. My second B part alters the diagonal pentatonic scale to follow the chord changes and ends yet again in a sixth over the D chord. Lastly, I use thirds in a different way to honor the changes and end with “The Marcel Lick” this time with a G string escape note.

BLACKBERRY BLOSSOM

AS PERFORMED BY MARCEL ARDANS
TABBED BY MARCEL ARDANS

Standard tuning

A PART

Chords: G, D, C, G, C_H, G, A7, D7

Measures 1-16 with guitar notation and tablature.

The first line of this break subverts two expectations: folks normally improvise descending lines here and they generally don't arpeggiate the many chords. I'm attempting to ascend and point out the third and root of every chord. Next I descend the neck using four enclosures around chord tones.

B PART

Chords: E_M, C, G, D, G

Measures 17-33 with guitar notation and tablature.

The third line begins with some diagonal ascending followed by some sixths and uncommon chord voicings. The second A part concludes with a quote from Beauty and the Beast and some arpeggios, note the implied 2 chord over the G chord in the second to last measure. The B part begins with a bluesy bend, this is something I've seen Trey Hensley do. Over the B7 I drop a bebop line with another sixth. This is followed by a common latin line cliché in the second line. The third line reinterprets the melody as a kind of funk bassline and our last line returns to the Trey Hensley bends and some classic bluegrass language to take us out.

CHEROKEE SHUFFLE

AS PERFORMED BY MARCEL ARDANS
TABBED BY MARCEL ARDANS

DGDGCE

A PART

Capo. fret 2

This is an odd one. I take advantage of the unique tuning by starting the melody an octave down. As I reach the end of this line I double a note on the D string which becomes a motif. The second line starts with some double stops that I really like the sound of and then the doubled note motif takes over.

B PART

In the third line, the melody starts in the standard octave with open string crosspicking. The last line continues using double stops in creative ways. The B part starts again with the melody and floating before descending the octave down and continuing the double stop theme. The next line ascends for two measures with a sequenced pattern of thirds. The third line reestablishes the melody with the higher alternate melody harmonized in sixths. Next we descend down the neck using a variation of “That One Tony Rice Lick” with no escape note. Briefly play an Em chord with a minor 6th before concluding.

SALT CREEK
AS PERFORMED BY MARCEL ARDANS
TABBED BY MARCEL ARDANS

Standard tuning

A PART

Capo. fret 2

This break begins with the Tony Rice B string bend. This fills a hole where someone had a hard stop in their break, it just made more sense in the edit. The melody starts with a double stop interpretation and a syncopation into the second line, notice I’m always trying to play a C where the C chord shows up.

B PART

My third line plays the melody down the octave before using an F major diagonal pentatonic scale to ascend the neck. Then we use double stops instead of a drone to play the melody up the octave, finally using “That One Tony Rice Lick” with a G string escape note to finish. The B part starts with a double stop, a bluesy take of the melody, another double stop, and then the “Old Train lick” on the F chord. The next line uses “hot lick” style language. Starting my second pass of the B part I use octaves of G instead of double stops, followed by a major pentatonic triplet lick. Then a double stop over the F chord and the same lick transposed up so it’s minor pentatonic. This gives me the chance to play a long linear descending phrase in the last line. I’m very fond of these lines.

GOLD RUSH
AS PERFORMED BY MARCEL ARDANS
TABBED BY MARCEL ARDANS
Standard tuning

A PART

1 Capo. fret 2

2 3 4 5

6 7 8 9

10 11 12 13

14 15 16 17

I have a running motif through this break, it's the “nanny nanny boo boo” sound. I heard it in another submission and it immediatelly became stuck in my mind. It appears twice in the first A part, once in the tag of the second A part, and once at the very end. The first A part also includes a variation of “The Marcel Lick” to ascend the neck followed by a challenging interpretation of the melody the octave up.

B PART

18 19 20 21

22 23 24 25

26 27 28 29

30 31 32 33

The second A part uses the melody itself as a motific inspiration, the ascending pick up is repeated three times using different scale degrees before it resolves by way of a floating lick and two harmonics. The first B part is playing closed and up the octave. It is a relatively straight interpretation of the melody and requires the use of double stops up at the twelfth fret. This closes with a “hot lick” played in the middle of the fretboard. The second B part mirrors the second A part with a stuttering lick played three times with different scale degrees. The third repition descends a pentatonic box and allows me to take an escape note to the open shapes. I close the melody in a fairly standard way, with the exception of another “nanny nanny boo boo” and the second half of a “shave and a hair cut” played with double stops.